

never had one, either in Paris or here in India. I like to read the newspaper every day and I do listen to the radio but have never watched TV.”

Ask Grewal about what led her to fashion and being an Indian designer in Paris, and she is quite candid. “I never knew fashion would be my calling since I had never undertaken a formal course in design, nor did I work with sketches. In fact, I was a journalist with no connection at all with fashion,” she says in her charming way. There was a trigger, though, but more on that later.

HERS HAS TRULY been a chequered journey. Grewal, born in Lahore, moved with her family to Patiala a night before Independence. At a time when very few women pursued higher education in India, she went about her studies with zeal, setting her sights to study at a university abroad.

Finally, she got lucky. In 1952, she travelled to the US after winning a scholarship to pursue a Master’s in Political Science at the University of California, Los Angeles. She followed this up with a PhD at the University of California, Berkeley. “I owe the urge for gaining higher knowledge to my father. He was so passionate about education, and this was the greatest gift he gave me,” she says. While still a student, Mohanjeet worked as a guide with the UN; after finishing her studies, she worked as a journalist with the now-defunct *New York Herald Tribune* newspaper, and later *The New York Times*, before leaving for Vienna to work at the International Atomic Energy Agency. She then moved to Paris to work for Unesco.

She recalls an incident while working for the UN agency. One day, she was in the US, dressed in a saree, which she regularly used to wear to the office. Someone looked at her attire and asked, ‘Are you from Israel?’ It was then that she realised that no one outside of Unesco knew about India and what it has to offer. That was the trigger. “All I wanted was to showcase and sell India’s craftsmanship to the world. I came back to rediscover India, and I was so excited by the vibrant colours of Rajasthan, the brightness and spark all around, which was in complete contrast to the blacks and the greys of the West. Even if one were to come with a mission to find something ugly in India, they would not be able to find it,” says an animated Mohanjeet.

The first few things she designed for the fashionable French were red coolie shirts and pocketed vests in menswear. Later, she went on to sell white *chikankari* kurtas from Lucknow and khadi kurtas in different colours. Then she created the bold mini-sari with the



hemline above the knee in 1967 and later gold-rimmed dhotis styled as wraparounds, which put her creations on the pages of top French fashion magazines. What put her in the top league was the freewheeling bohemian chic style, which she introduced to Paris in the Sixties. It made her so popular that at one point in time, she was running seven stores in the fashion capital, with even the French designers imitating her style.

Her influence began infiltrating the wardrobes of prominent clients including actresses Catherine Deneuve, Jane Fonda and Brigitte Bardot, and even Princess Caroline of Monaco and the famous designer, Yves Saint Laurent. Not just her clothes, her clients loved being served cardamom and clove tea when they visited the store.

“Yonks back, I remember when I had done a show in Paris, I was walking near Saint Honoré Street (a leg-

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“Mohanjeet clearly ruled the Paris fashion scene in the Seventies and the rag trade belonged to her. She is known for many innovative ideas, and clearly did it before everyone else”

Rina Dhaka, FASHION DESIGNER